

What is it?

Rahul's joined the online project SETI@home — a part of the project SERENDIP started by the Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence or SETI institute. He downloaded the SETI@home software. Like every other computer, his computer also carries a lot of unused processing cycles. So, whenever he is not working on his computer, he leaves it on for the software to make use of that idle time. The software downloads a 300 kB chunk of data that comes from the Arecibo Radio Telescope, in Puerto Rico. Different packets of data are sent to the thousands of computers which have downloaded the SETI software for similar analysis. The results of the analysis from all these computers are ultimately sent back to the SERENDIP team and used to help in the search for extraterrestrial signals. In this way, a 2.5 MHz band of the observed spectrum is processed in the SETI@home project, across the world, and then finally comes back to the one nodal point. The process — grid computing — is one of the many ways in which virtualisation is all set to revolutionise our world.

A NASSCOM report refers to virtualisation as the next 'disruptive' technology (the previous one being the internet). Much like the internet, it has the capacity to change the way organisations work. By creating virtual space for data storage and maximising server capacities, it allows companies to reduce storage and power costs drastically. Data sharing becomes more simple as all servers are inter-connected. Hence, problems that would require access to large amounts of data, or a large number of processing cycles, can be solved much faster. This improved efficiency gives companies a huge gain in power, speed and collaboration.

Why is it needed?

At the industry level, there are two kinds of virtualisations that are in use commercially — storage virtualisation and server virtualisation. While the former helps to expand the storage capacities of companies through virtualising and hence expanding storage space, server virtualisation helps in implementing out that storage in the least server space possible. Both of them use complex methods to attain these objectives and both help in cutting down companies cost substantially.

There's another buzz word in the virtualisation industry – cloud computing. IBM, Amazon, Google, Microsoft, Yahoo and more recently, AT&T, have already entered this race to the clouds. The technology helps save information

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